‘The GDR has announced that its borders are open to everyone as of now. The gates of the wall are now wide open.’ Honecker remembered sitting open-mouthed at home watching events unfold on TV: ‘It was something surreal, something inexplicable for everyone whose future, whose hopes were bound up with the GDR, for those who worked and fought for four decades. And it was an act that practically liquidated the GDR.’8

All through the night, East Berliners surged into West Berlin, many dancing along the Kurfurstendamm in a raucous outpouring of joy. Bars offered free drinks to their unexpected guests, while the underground ran all night to cope with the extraordinary mass of people moving around in a stunned, jubilant city. ‘It was so simple to come over,’ a young East Berliner told TV reporters. ‘The feeling is just indescribable.’ Former Chancellor Willy Brandt – forcing himself to hold back tears – said the GDR would never be the same again: ‘The people of divided Germany have come together.’

From here on, the SED reaped the whirlwind. A week later, Krenz took a swipe at his former boss by declaring the difficult position was not the blame of rank-and-file communists, workers, peasants or intellectuals. ‘Our party’s leadership is to blame for that,’ he said. ‘Former party leader Erich Honecker also bears personal responsibility for the mistakes. But considering his age and health, he should be given the right to decide himself when to make a public assessment of his actions.’9

On 3 December, the Politburo and the Central Committee resigned and Krenz threw in the sponge as party leader but remained head of state and chairman of the Defence Council. That same day, several senior members of the old guard – including Honecker – were unceremoniously expelled from the SED. Meanwhile, the state prosecutor’s office launched a search of Alexander Schalck-Golodkowski’s office, who, reluctant to commit his valuable person to authorities, had fled abroad. Proceedings were instituted against him for abuse of office, personal gain and favouritism.10 As the days passed, more reports emerged about the SED’s abuse of power and the magnitude of the dire economic situation. Günter Schabowski remembers the Politburo engaged in some ‘aggressive, impatient’ discussion on the situation: